Background Guide for the Conference of Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change

Committee Overview

Introduction

The Conference of Parties (COP) is the decision-making body for the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC). The UNFCCC is an international treaty that was adopted in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil at the Earth Summit in 1992. It entered into force on March 21, 1994. The goal of the UNFCCC is to prevent "dangerous" human interference with the climate system and to stabilize greenhouse gas (GHG) concentrations. The UNFCCC has 197 parties, including all UN Member States. All States parties are represented at the COP.

Two important documents within the UNFCCC are the Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement. The Kyoto Protocol to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (Kyoto Protocol) was adopted on December 11, 1997 at the third session of the COP and went into force on February 16, 2005. The Kyoto Protocol set binding GHG emissions targets for developed countries. Only developed countries were required to meet these targets at the Kyoto Protocol recognized that that are the countries that were responsible for the current high levels of GHGs in the atmosphere. On December 12, 2015 at the 21st session of COP, the Paris Agreement was adopted by consensus. It later went into force on November 4, 2016. The central goal of the Paris Agreement is to keep global temperature rise within this century to under 2 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels and to strengthen the abilities of countries to adapt to climate change. The Paris Agreement requires all States parties to set national determined contributions (NDCs), which describe efforts taken by each country to achieve the goals laid out in the Paris Agreement. Unlike the Kyoto Protocol, there are no distinctions between developed and developing countries; it only calls upon States parties to individually determine their NDCs and report on their progress.

The COP meets annually to review emissions inventories submitted by Parties and assess the progress made towards the achievement of the UNFCCC and the Paris Agreement. The most recent meeting, COP 26, took place in November 2021 in Glasgow, Scotland. It is critical to know the results of this meeting, including both its accomplishments and its shortcomings.

Mandate

As the "supreme body" of the UNFCCC, the COP plays an integral role of the implementation of the convention. According to article 7.2, the mandate of the COP is to review the implementation of the UNFCC, as well as any related legal instruments, such as the Kyoto Protocol and Paris

Agreement. The COP is responsible for examining States parties' commitments to the UNFCCC as well as new scientific findings in the implementation of climate change policies, promoting and facilitating information sharing on measures adopted by Parties to address climate change, assess the progress made by States parties towards the achievements of the Convention, and make recommendations for the implementation of the Convention. Further responsibilities are described in Chapter 2 of the UNFCCC Handbook (2006). The COP meets annually for a session of around two weeks, unless Parties decide otherwise.

In addition, the UNFCCC outlines the responsibilities of the Bureau and the Secretariat, both which support the work of the COP. The Bureau consists of 11 elected representatives, with two members each representing the five regional groups (Africa, Asia, Eastern Europe, Latin America and the Caribbean, Western Europe and other States), and one member representing Small Island Developing States. The Bureau is responsible for questions of process management and assisting the President of the Bureau with their duties. The Bureau also examines the credentials of parties, reviews NGOs and IGOs seeking accreditation, and submitting necessary reports to the COP. The Secretariat consists of 450 staff members which are led by the Executive Secretary, a position currently held by Patricia Espinosa. The Secretariat is responsible for organizing and two to four negotiating sessions each year, the largest of which being the COP. It also provides technical expertise, assists in the analysis and review of climate change information, and maintains the registry for NDCs established by the Paris Agreement.

Conclusion

As the implementing body of the UNFCCC, the COP plays an important role in the global community's response to climate change. With the threat of climate change always increasing, the work of the COP has become especially important. In order to mitigate climate change, States parties must work to reduce their greenhouse gas emissions and prevent global temperatures from rising. Realizing the promise of the Paris Agreement will assist Member States in accomplishing these goals and protecting the environment for future generations. Through the involvement of youth in climate action, the empowerment of developing countries to fight climate change through capacity-building measures, and the use of sustainable agriculture to ensure food security, Member States can begin to adapt and mitigate the challenges that they will face due to climate change.

Realizing the Promise of the Paris Agreement

Background

Climate change poses serious threats to life on earth. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) has reported that failing to limit global temperature rise to 1.5 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels would result in serious consequences for natural ecosystems and human life, resulting in biodiversity loss, food insecurity, decreased water supply, and other negative impacts. However, the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) has reported that based on current trends, it is expected that there will be an average global temperature increase between 3 and 5 degrees Celsius by 2100. This will result in serious and potentially irreversible damage, including changing weather patterns, sea level rise, and a higher likelihood for extreme temperatures and drought. Certain populations will have a disproportionately higher risk of adverse consequences of climate change. These populations include those in developing countries, populations that are dependent on local agriculture, and coastal areas, including Small

Island Developing States. Through the realization of the Paris Agreement, the global community can both mitigate climate change, which includes efforts to reduce GHG emissions into the atmosphere, and adapt to climate change, which includes efforts that can reduce the negative impacts where climate change has already progressed.

The Paris Agreement seeks to limit global average temperature increase to well below 2 degrees Celsius, and as close to 1.5 degrees Celsius as possible. The Paris Agreement requires States parties to prepare, communicate, and maintain nationally determined contributions (NDCs). NDCs outline how individual State parties intend to mitigate and adapt to climate change. NDCs are submitted every five years to the UNFCCC Secretariat. While Member States play an important role in the reduction of greenhouse gas emissions, the Paris Agreement recognizes that local governments, businesses, civil society, and other actors can work to prevent climate change. There are actions that we can all take to mitigate and adapt to climate change.

The Role of Youth in Achieving the Paris Agreement

The involvement of youth is essential in achieving the Paris Agreement. As of 2022, there are 1.3 billion youth between the ages of 15 and 24 years old, which accounts for 16% of the global population. As a significant part of the world's population, youth have the power to push our global community toward a low-carbon, climate resilient future, as well as the achievement of the Paris Agreement.

Youth have been involved in the fight against climate change for several. Since 2008, the United Nations Joint Framework Initiative on Children, Youth, and Climate Change (Joint Framework Initiative) has worked to empower youth to participate in climate change policy decision-making processes. The Joint Framework Initiative is coordinated by the UNFCCC Secretariat, and works with 16 intergovernmental organizations, including the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO), the United Nations Children's Fund, and others, as well as several youth organizations to enhance the participation of youth in climate change mitigation and adaptation. In 2009, the official Youth Constituency to the UNFCC (YOUNGO) was formed. YOUNGO brings together youth organizations and individuals from around the world to strengthen the international youth climate movement and involve future generations in developing climate solutions. While youth have gathered informally since 2005 to have their voices heard at meetings of the COP, in 2009 at COP 15, the UNFCCC officially recognized youth as an observer constituency. Since then, YOUNGO has hosted an annual Conference of Youth (COY) the night before the yearly gathering of the COP. The aim of the COY is to compile the input of youth from various nations and regions to be fed into climate change negotiations.

Outside of official climate negotiations, youth around the world have taken action to mitigate and adapt to climate change at local, regional, and international levels. In Barbados, secondary-school students have implemented a project to raise awareness about the use of biodiesel as an alternative fuel source. By collecting 3,943 liters of used vegetable oil from their communities, students were able to collaborate with a local business to convert the vegetable oil into biodiesel, which was used and resulted in a reduction of 6,000 tons of CO2 emissions. In Madagascar, the Cyclone Proof Schools Project, in partnership with UNICEF, has worked to rebuild 20 schools that were impacted by cyclones and improve their resilience to future extreme weather events caused by climate change. Students at these rebuilt schools are then able to nurture community gardens, where they are able to learn about sustainable agriculture and biodiversity.

Capacity-Building for Combating Climate Change in Developing Countries

As climate change, its effects on the planet, and its threats to the world begin to be better understood, the need for developing and strengthening capacity building measures becomes more imminent than ever. COP to the UNFCCC has recognized the needs of developing countries and the unique challenges they face in achieving the goals set by the various climate change frameworks. COP has, thus, recognized that in order for climate objectives to be consistently met, developing countries must be empowered to enhance their capacities in implementing adaptation strategies.

As defined by the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (1992) (UNFCCC), capacity-building is a process that strengthens the abilities of institutions, systems, and individuals to implement climate change mitigation and adaptation objectives. The Conference of the Parties (COP) categorizes capacity-building efforts as individual, institutional, and systemic. *Individual Capacity Building* is focused on increasing the public awareness of climate change through education and outreach. *Institutional Capacity Building* is based around increasing the capacity of organizations to react to and prepare for climate change in the public and private sectors and how these groups cooperate with one another. *Systemic Capacity-Building* is the most broad in its objectives, primarily creating 'enabling environments' for combating climate change through the removal of legislative barriers, the harmonization of economic and environmental policies, and an increase in transparency. Although the UNFCCC constituted one of the first multilateral frameworks against climate change, its underlying principles can be traced back to the United Nations Conference on the Human Environment (Stockholm Conference) (1971). This early framework included recognition, outlined in Principles 9-11, that developing countries may lack the economic and infrastructural development required to adequately and sustainably protect their environments. This was continued in the report of the World Commission on Environment and Development, Our Common Future (1987). These early concepts were developed with the adoption of the UNFCCC in 1992.

As the governing body of UNFCCC and its related frameworks, COP maintains primary responsibility for the oversight, planning, and review of the broad objectives of capacity-building in developing countries. As outlined in the Marrakech Accords, COP is tasked with regularly monitoring and reviewing the implementation of the UNFCCC, Kyoto Protocol, Paris Agreement, and other climate frameworks. The financial mechanisms facilitating the transfer of funds to developing countries for capacity-building, are largely managed by the Global Environment Facility (GEF) and the Green Climate Fund (GCF). Specifically, the GEF administers the specialized Least Developed Countries Fund, designed to support developing countries in the implementation of their National Adaptation Plans (NAPs). The UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs (DESA) also operates multiple global capacity development projects. Both the World Bank and the GEF, alongside private development funds, provide funding for national & regional projects on environmental capacity-building, with the administration of these being overseen by relevant national governments.

Sustainable Agriculture and Climate Change

A changing climate threatens the survival of humanity and becomes a significant hindrance to reducing inequality and achieving sustainable development for all. Climate change can negatively affect the availability and stability of the food supply, reduce the safety of food and water, and exacerbate extreme poverty levels that limit access to food. Agriculture is a major

source of greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions and contributes to climate change through deforestation, the production of livestock, and the administration of nutrients and fertilizers in the soil. Shifting to sustainable agricultural practices is vital to meet the ecological, societal, and institutional challenges of the future and is a valuable means of climate change mitigation.

750 million people, including almost two-thirds of those in extreme poverty, earn their livelihoods through agriculture. The linkages between climate change and sustainable development are strong. Supporting small-scale farmers, introducing sustainable agriculture, ending poverty, ensuring human health, and addressing climate change are all aspects of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Climate finance is an essential approach that encompasses the economic resources required for mitigating and adapting to climate change and the financial flows to Least Developed Countries (LDCs) that enable them to act. The Conference of the Parties (COP) of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) (1992) is directly addressing climate change and sustainable agriculture within its work and the work of its bodies. In 1992, UNFCCC was adopted at the Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro. Article 2 of the Convention affirms the importance of protecting food production, while Article 4 names agriculture as a crucial sector for action. The Earth Summit also saw several other developments, including the creation of Agenda 21, a global plan of action on sustainable development that the United Nations (UN), other multilateral organizations, and individual governments can implement. COP is the most important platform for discussions on climate change adaptation and mitigation within the UN system.

Climate change is projected to have increasingly negative impacts on agriculture. Progress toward sustainable agriculture is slow and increased investment is necessary to catalyze development, mitigation and adaptation strategies, and enhance agricultural productivity. The UNFCCC Secretariat has advocated for the integration of responses to sustainable development, climate change, and disaster risk reduction, considering the centrality of these topics to the UNFCCC and the global agenda in the post-2015 period. Governments, NGOs, and individuals must work together to craft policies that properly address the deficiencies in current approaches and ensure that agriculture becomes sustainable.

Conclusion

Climate change is projected to have negative impacts on many aspects of life around the world, but Member States' commitments to furthering the goals of the Paris Agreement can prevent unnecessary environmental harm from occurring. The COP has worked to bring the States Parties of the UNFCCC together to negotiate and assess the progress they have made to reduce GHG emissions. Climate change is a defining issue of our time, and the global community must work to ensure that all members of society, especially youth and people in developing countries, are actively engaged in mitigating its effects.

Further Questions

How can Member States encourage youth to take action against climate change? How can youth help their local communities mitigate and adapt to climate change? How can the UNFCCC work to engage youth in rural areas and developing countries? How can the COP work to build capacity in developing countries? How can the COP coordinate with other actors to streamline capacity-building efforts? How can emissions reductions be incentivized within the agricultural sector? How can Member States shift to sustainable agricultural practices while protecting the livelihood of those dependent on agriculture?

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Helpful Resources

https://www.un.org/en/sections/issues-depth/climate-change/

https://www.un.org/sustainabledevelopment/climate-change/

https://unfccc.int/process/bodies/supreme-bodies/conference-of-the-parties-cop

https://unfccc.int/process-and-meetings/the-convention/what-is-the-united-nations-framework-convention-on-climate-change

https://unfccc.int/kyoto_protocol

https://unfccc.int/process-and-meetings/the-paris-agreement/the-paris-agreement